TRADE ADVISOR · MARKET INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Sulphur to South Korea

Delivered cost from every source country

HS 2503.00 · delivered Busan → client · 100 t and 1,000 t lots · 30 October 2026

CHEAPEST OPEN SOURCE

China

$859/t delivered
1,000 t lot

BEST CIS SOURCE

Uzbekistan

$913/t delivered
1,000 t lot

COUNTRIES OPEN NOW

10 of 22

others banned, sanctioned or disrupted (Oct 2026)

Prepared for a Kazakhstan-national trader resident in South Korea. Estimates built from October 2026 benchmarks, not supplier quotes. Verify with a licensed Korean customs broker, freight forwarder and supplier before committing money.

01 · EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Where to buy, and what it costs delivered

Every realistic sulphur source was costed the same way: purchase price at origin, export fees and bagging, freight to Busan in 20ft containers (25 t each), insurance, Korean duty, port and hazmat delivery, financing and an FX buffer.

Cheapest legal source today: China at **$859/t** delivered for 1,000 t (5% margin at $900/t).

Best CIS source: Uzbekistan at **$913/t** (-1% margin).

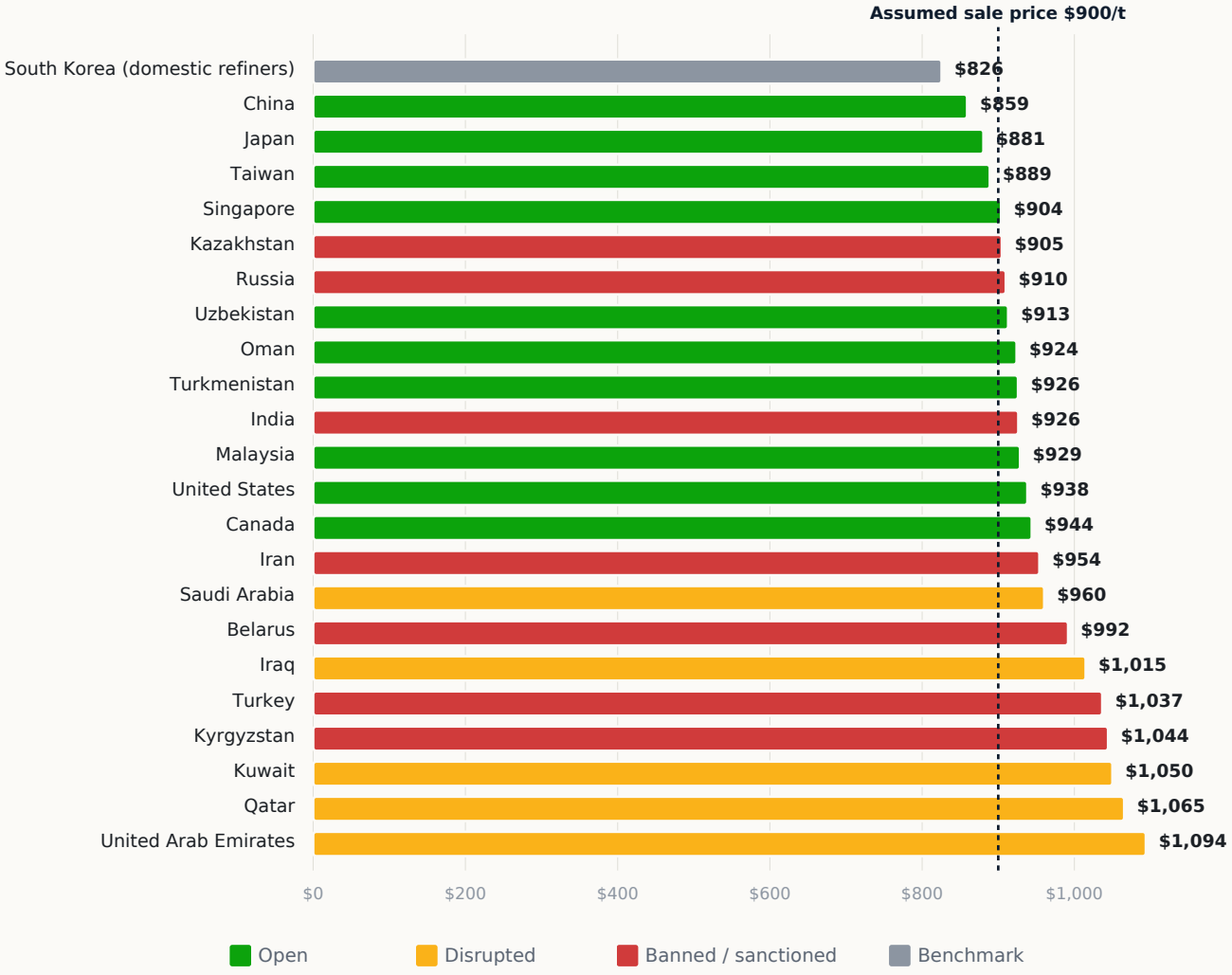
Korean domestic benchmark (South Korea (domestic refiners)): $826/t, which is what your clients can already get locally.

Only **10 of 22** priced source countries are open; the rest are under export bans, sanctions or shipping disruption (marked in grey in the tables).

02 · COMPARISON

Delivered cost per tonne, 1,000 t lot

Bars to the left of the dashed line are below the assumed $900/t sale price; the gap is your gross profit per tonne.



03 · RANKING

Every country, ranked by delivered cost

Cost per tonne delivered to the client in Korea, ex-VAT (VAT is recoverable). *Margin at 1,000 t and an assumed sale price of $900/t.

#	Country	Status	Route to Busan	Days	Buy $/t	Freight $/t	100 t $/t	1,000 t $/t	Margin *
1	**South Korea (domestic refiners)**	BENCHMARK	Truck refinery -> client (no import)	1	$800	$0	$826	**$826**	8%
2	**China**	OPEN	Truck to Qingdao/Lianyungang/Shanghai -> container to Busan	3	$760	$20	$876	**$859**	5%
3	**Japan**	OPEN	Japanese port (Osaka/Kobe/Moji) -> container to Busan	3	$790	$16	$897	**$881**	2%
4	**Taiwan**	OPEN	Kaohsiung/Taichung -> container to Busan	4	$790	$24	$906	**$889**	1%
5	**Singapore**	OPEN	Singapore -> container to Busan	7	$800	$28	$921	**$904**	0%
6	**Kazakhstan**	BANNED	Rail Atyrau -> Altynkol/Khorgos or Dostyk -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> feeder to Busan	28	$700	$135	$922	**$905**	−1%
7	**Russia**	BANNED	Rail Astrakhan/Orenburg -> Trans-Siberian -> Vostochny/Vladivostok -> sea to Busan	28	$720	$120	$927	**$910**	−1%
8	**Uzbekistan**	OPEN	Rail Mubarek -> Saryagash (KZ transit) -> Altynkol/Khorgos -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan	30	$680	$141	$930	**$913**	−1%
9	**Oman**	OPEN	Sohar or Duqm -> Arabian Sea -> Malacca -> Busan	22	$765	$80	$941	**$924**	−3%
10	**Turkmenistan**	OPEN	Rail TM -> Uzbekistan/Kazakhstan transit -> Altynkol -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan	32	$680	$153	$943	**$926**	−3%
11	**India**	BANNED	Mundra/Pipavav -> Malacca -> Busan	18	$800	$48	$943	**$926**	−3%
12	**Malaysia**	OPEN	Pasir Gudang / Port Klang -> container to Busan	9	$820	$32	$946	**$929**	−3%
13	**United States**	OPEN	LA/Long Beach or Portland -> transpacific container -> Busan	16	$818	$32	$955	**$938**	−4%
14	**Canada**	OPEN	Rail Alberta -> Vancouver -> transpacific container (westbound backhaul) -> Busan	14	$820	$36	$961	**$944**	−5%
15	**Iran**	SANCTIONED	Bandar Abbas -> Strait of Hormuz -> Busan (hypothetical)	30	$715	$140	$971	**$954**	−6%
16	**Saudi Arabia**	DISRUPTED	Yanbu/Jeddah -> Bab el-Mandeb -> Indian Ocean -> Malacca -> Busan	24	$765	$100	$977	**$960**	−7%
17	**Belarus**	SANCTIONED	Rail Belarus -> Russia -> Kazakhstan -> China -> Lianyungang -> Busan	35	$720	$180	$1,009	**$992**	−10%
18	**Iraq**	DISRUPTED	Umm Qasr -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Busan	35	$755	$152	$1,032	**$1,015**	−13%
19	**Turkey**	BANNED	Izmit/Aliaga -> Suez -> Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb -> Busan	35	$880	$72	$1,054	**$1,037**	−15%

#	Country	Status	Route to Busan	Days	Buy $/t	Freight $/t	100 t $/t	1,000 t $/t	Margin *
20	**Kyrgyzstan**	BANNED	Truck Bishkek -> Torugart/Irkeshtam -> Kashgar -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan	38	$760	$209	$1,061	**$1,044**	−16%
21	**Kuwait**	DISRUPTED	Shuwaikh/Shuaiba -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Malacca -> Busan	35	$820	$140	$1,067	**$1,050**	−17%
22	**Qatar**	DISRUPTED	Hamad Port -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Malacca -> Busan	35	$835	$140	$1,082	**$1,065**	−18%
23	**United Arab Emirates**	DISRUPTED	Truck Ruwais -> Khor Fakkan (east coast, outside Hormuz) -> container via Strait of Malacca -> Busan	25	$890	$100	$1,111	**$1,094**	−22%
24	**Azerbaijan**	OPEN	Rail Baku -> Poti/Batumi (Georgia) -> sea via Suez/Red Sea -> Busan	50	n/a	-	-	-	-
25	**Indonesia**	OPEN	Jakarta/Surabaya -> container to Busan	10	n/a	-	-	-	-

04 · COUNTRY PROFILES

Route, status and cost stack per country

Cost stack per tonne at 1,000 t. The coloured edge shows the export status.

South Korea (domestic refiners)

BENCHMARK

BENCHMARK: Korea is a net sulphur exporter (S-Oil Onsan, SK Energy Ulsan, GS Caltex Yeosu, HD Hyundai Oilbank Daesan); South Korea was China's largest sulphur supplier Jan-Jul 2026 (516 kt). Korean clients can buy domestically, so any import must beat this price.

Route: Truck refinery -> client (no import) (truck, ~1 days)
Buy: $800/t ex-refinery/FCA ESTIMATE = export parity (CFR China granular $800-850 on 22 Oct minus ~$25-35 freight); actual domestic contract prices not published · **Freight:** $0/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (domestic (no duty))
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$800
Origin fees + bagging	$0
Freight	$0
Insurance	$0
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$20
Finance + FX	$6
Delivered	**$826**

China

OPEN

No ban on elemental sulphur exports found (China bans SULPHURIC ACID exports May-Dec 2026). China is a large net importer, so exportable sulphur is scarce; domestic price fell sharply (ex-works RMB 5,400-5,550 on 22 Oct vs RMB 9,875 peak in June).

Route: Truck to Qingdao/Lianyungang/Shanghai -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~3 days)
Buy: $760/t FOB China ESTIMATE from ex-works RMB 5,475/t (22 Oct, incl. 13% VAT; ~$720 ex-VAT at ~6.72 CNY/USD) + port costs; 0% export VAT rebate · **Freight:** $500/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-China FTA and RCEP: 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$775
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$20
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$15
Delivered	**$859**

Japan

OPEN

No restriction found. Japanese refiners are sulphur exporters (mainly to China) but no 2026 FOB Japan sulphur price was found (the $310-320/t 'FOB Japan/Korea' figure in CRU is SULPHURIC ACID, not sulphur).

Route: Japanese port (Osaka/Kobe/Moji) -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~3 days)
Buy: $790/t FOB Japan ESTIMATE (export parity: CFR China granular $800-850 on 22 Oct minus ~$25-35 freight) · **Freight:** $400/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (RCEP (Korea-Japan); WTO 0% anyway)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$800
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$16
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$15
Delivered	**$881**

Taiwan

OPEN

No restriction found. CPC/Formosa refineries produce sulphur; CPC domestic quote up ~95% YTD by June 2026. No export FOB found.

Route: Kaohsiung/Taichung -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~4 days)
Buy: $790/t FOB Taiwan ESTIMATE (regional export parity, CFR China minus freight) · **Freight:** $600/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none (WTO member Chinese Taipei: 0%))
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$800
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$24
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$15
Delivered	**$889**

Singapore

OPEN

Open, but small refinery output (Jurong Island); Singapore is mainly a TRADING hub - many offers are Middle East-origin re-sales. The certificate of origin will show the real (often Gulf) origin; do not treat it as Singapore-origin.

Route: Singapore -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~7 days)
Buy: $800/t FOB Singapore ESTIMATE (ME spot $765 + regional trader premium); no published price · **Freight:** $700/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-Singapore FTA, ASEAN-Korea, RCEP: 0%)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$810
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$28
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$16
Delivered	**$904**

Kazakhstan

BANNED

Sulphur export suspended since 27 Jun 2026 (Energy Ministry Order No. 1363), only exception shipments to Russian rail stations; still in force per CRU Sep-Oct 2026, no lifting found 2026-10-30 (one CRU market line mentioning a 4 Aug lifting is contradicted by CRU's own news item and no official source).

Route: Rail Atyrau -> Altynkol/Khorgos or Dostyk -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> feeder to Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~28 days)
Buy: $700/t FCA plant, ESTIMATE (Baltic/Black Sea FOB $770-800 4Q26 contract minus ~$80-100 rail netback); no live offer possible while ban lasts · **Freight:** $3,375/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none (WTO member since 2015: Korea WTO concession rate 0%))
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$700
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$135
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$20
Delivered	**$905**

Russia

BANNED

Industrial sulphur export ban to 31 Dec 2026 (Decree 785); EAEU exempt. Decree 1059 (21 Aug 2026) opened a 300 kt export quota for LOWER-GRADE technical sulphur only. Heavy Western sanctions and Korean export controls on Russia: payment/bank risk even if quota material is available.

Route: Rail Astrakhan/Orenburg -> Trans-Siberian -> Vostochny/Vladivostok -> sea to Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~28 days)
Buy: $720/t FCA plant, ESTIMATE (Black/Baltic FOB 4Q26 $770-800 minus rail netback) · **Freight:** $3,000/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none (WTO member: 0% concession rate))
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$720
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$120
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$20
Delivered	**$910**

Uzbekistan

OPEN

No 2026 sulphur export ban found (searched 2026-10-30) but not confirmed by an official source. Sales via UzEx exchange / Uzbekneftegaz; export contracts registered in foreign trade e-system.

Route: Rail Mubarek -> Saryagash (KZ transit) -> Altynkol/Khorgos -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~30 days)
Buy: $680/t FCA, ESTIMATE (KB assumption; no published exchange price found) · **Freight:** $3,520/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not yet WTO member (accession talks ongoing 2026) -> 2% basic assumed (verify beneficial tariff))
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$685
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$141
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$17
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$21
Delivered	**$913**

Oman

OPEN

Sohar and Duqm are OUTSIDE the Strait of Hormuz; Oman was China's largest sulphur supplier Jan-May 2026 (541 kt). Still war-risk area (attacks reported near Sohar 21 Oct 2026, low-authority source); insurance premiums high.

Route: Sohar or Duqm -> Arabian Sea -> Malacca -> Busan (sea (containers; bulk normally), ~22 days)
Buy: $765/t FOB Middle East spot (22 Oct 2026 MTD avg; range $740-790). No Oman-specific price published. · **Freight:** $2,000/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none in force (Korea-GCC FTA not in force); WTO 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$775
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$80
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$19
Delivered	**$924**

Turkmenistan

OPEN

No export ban found (2026-10-30). Turkmengaz sells technical lump sulphur on the State Commodity Exchange (SCRMET); Oct 2026 foreign buyers incl. Turkiye, Singapore, UAE. Exchange prices not published. Avoid routing via Iran.

Route: Rail TM -> Uzbekistan/Kazakhstan transit -> Altynkol -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~32 days)
Buy: $680/t FCA, ESTIMATE (KB assumption; exchange price not published) · **Freight:** $3,820/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not WTO member -> 2% basic rate assumed (may get 0% if on Korea's beneficial-tariff list - verify))
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$685
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$153
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$17
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$21
Delivered	**$926**

India

BANNED

Sulphur exports halted since ~Jul 2026 (refiners told to prioritise domestic supply; no DGFT notification published). Hits Reliance (Jamnagar, loads Sikka/Bedi). Treat as closed until an official lifting.

Route: Mundra/Pipavav -> Malacca -> Busan (sea (containers), ~18 days)
Buy: $800/t FOB India ESTIMATE ('if open': CFR India $880-894 on 22 Oct minus freight) · **Freight:** $1,200/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-India CEPA (CEPA rate for 2503 not confirmed; WTO 0% anyway))
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$810
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$48
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$19
Delivered	**$926**

Malaysia

OPEN

Petronas RAPID (Pengerang) and other refineries produce granular sulphur; no 2026 export price found. Region (Indonesia) is a large importer, so exportable surplus is limited.

Route: Pasir Gudang / Port Klang -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~9 days)
Buy: $820/t FOB Malaysia ESTIMATE (between ME spot $765 and CFR Indonesia $850-860) · **Freight:** $800/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (ASEAN-Korea FTA, RCEP (Korea-Malaysia FTA signed); 0%)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$830
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$32
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$17
Delivered	**$929**

United States

OPEN

Open; refinery sulphur on the West Coast. KORUS 0%. US Gulf supply ($840-860 FOB) is far from Korea; West Coast is the practical lane.

Route: LA/Long Beach or Portland -> transpacific container -> Busan (sea (containers), ~16 days)
Buy: $818/t FOB US West Coast, spot 22 Oct 2026 ($800-835) · **Freight:** $800/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (KORUS FTA: 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$838
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$32
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$18
Delivered	**$938**

Canada

OPEN

Open and reliable; Vancouver commanded a premium in Aug-Sep 2026 as buyers avoided Gulf delivery risk. Large Alberta producers sell bulk; small container lots via traders/distributors.

Route: Rail Alberta -> Vancouver -> transpacific container (westbound backhaul) -> Busan (rail+sea (containers; bulk normally), ~14 days)
Buy: $820/t FOB Vancouver bulk, spot 22 Oct 2026 ($800-840; 4Q26 contract $800-840) · **Freight:** $900/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-Canada FTA: 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$840
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$36
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$18
Delivered	**$944**

Iran

SANCTIONED

Comprehensive US (OFAC) sanctions, UN snapback sanctions (Sept 2025), active 2026 war with US/Israel; Korean banks/companies comply. Importing Iranian-origin sulphur is NOT lawful for practical purposes. Figures below are 'cost if open' only.

Route: Bandar Abbas -> Strait of Hormuz -> Busan (hypothetical) (sea (containers), ~30 days)
Buy: $715/t FOB Iran lump-granular, spot assessment 22 Oct 2026 (range $700-730) · **Freight:** $3,500/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not WTO member -> 2% basic)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$725
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$140
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$18
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$22
Delivered	**$954**

Saudi Arabia

DISRUPTED

Gulf-coast Jubail/Ras Al-Khair blocked by Hormuz; Aramco/Ma'aden sulphur now routed via Red Sea ports Yanbu/Rabigh/Jizan (Argus). Red Sea exit via Bab el-Mandeb exposed to Houthi attacks (Jazan facilities hit, Aug-Sep 2026).

Route: Yanbu/Jeddah -> Bab el-Mandeb -> Indian Ocean -> Malacca -> Busan (sea (containers from Jeddah/KAEC), ~24 days)
Buy: $765/t FOB Middle East spot (22 Oct 2026 MTD avg; range $740-790). No published Aramco price. · **Freight:** $2,500/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none in force (Korea-GCC FTA not in force); WTO 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$790
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$100
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$21
Delivered	**$960**

Belarus

SANCTIONED

Refineries Naftan (US-sanctioned) and Mozyr (EU 21st package, 23 Jul 2026). Rail to Asia must transit Russia. Avoid.

Route: Rail Belarus -> Russia -> Kazakhstan -> China -> Lianyungang -> Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~35 days)
Buy: $720/t FCA refinery, ESTIMATE (Baltic FOB $780-800 minus netback) · **Freight:** $4,500/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not WTO member -> 2% basic assumed)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$720
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$180
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$18
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$23
Delivered	**$992**

Iraq

DISRUPTED

Small, irregular exporter: SOMO marketed sulphur ~$755/t (May 2026); first 2026 cargo reported 30 Jun. Umm Qasr is at the head of the Gulf, behind Hormuz; illegal stockpiles/smuggling cases reported - buy only via SOMO with export authorisation.

Route: Umm Qasr -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Busan (sea (containers; bulk normally), ~35 days)
Buy: $755/t SOMO average export price, May 2026 (basis not stated, assume FOB) · **Freight:** $3,800/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not WTO member -> 2% basic)
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$770
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$152
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$19
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$24
Delivered	**$1,015**

Turkey

BANNED

Export ban on HS 2503 from 7 Apr 2026 for Q2-Q3 2026 (Ministry of Trade); no report found of lifting or extension for Q4 (checked 2026-10-30) - treat as banned until an official notice says otherwise.

Route: Izmit/Aliaga -> Suez -> Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb -> Busan (sea (containers), ~35 days)
Buy: $880/t FCA, Tupras August 2026 domestic tender $849-912/t · **Freight:** $1,800/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-Turkey FTA: 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$890
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$72
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$25
Delivered	**$1,037**

Kyrgyzstan

BANNED

No domestic sulphur production; stock held by Kyrgyz traders is Kazakh/Russian origin, so the KZ/RU export bans still apply to its origin. Re-export = circumvention risk; not recommended.

Route: Truck Bishkek -> Torugart/Irkeshtam -> Kashgar -> China rail -> Lianyungang -> Busan (truck+rail+sea (containers), ~38 days)
Buy: $760/t trader ex-warehouse, ESTIMATE (CIS FCA + $50-100 trader margin) · **Freight:** $5,220/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none (WTO member: 0%))
Confidence: Low

Purchase	$760
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$209
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$25
Delivered	**$1,044**

Kuwait

DISRUPTED

Shuaiba/Mina al-Ahmadi deep inside the Gulf. Strait of Hormuz effectively closed/restricted (28-29 Oct 2026: ~2-7% of normal traffic, mine strikes on tankers, Iran demands transit permits). Sulphur exits Gulf at ~55% of pre-war pace (Kpler, 26 Oct); Maersk suspended Gulf bookings; only ~2 containerships/week entering Gulf (Drewry wk 42).

Route: Shuwaikh/Shuaiba -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Malacca -> Busan (sea (containers; bulk normally), ~35 days)
Buy: $820/t FOB Kuwait bulk, KPC KSP Oct 2026 (contract) · **Freight:** $3,500/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none in force (Korea-GCC FTA not in force); WTO 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$835
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$140
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$25
Delivered	**$1,050**

Qatar

DISRUPTED

Ras Laffan/Mesaieed inside Hormuz. Strait of Hormuz effectively closed/restricted (28-29 Oct 2026: ~2-7% of normal traffic, mine strikes on tankers, Iran demands transit permits). Sulphur exits Gulf at ~55% of pre-war pace (Kpler, 26 Oct); Maersk suspended Gulf bookings; only ~2 containerships/week entering Gulf (Drewry wk 42).

Route: Hamad Port -> Strait of Hormuz (restricted) -> Malacca -> Busan (sea (containers; bulk normally), ~35 days)
Buy: $835/t FOB Qatar bulk, QSP Oct 2026 (contract) · **Freight:** $3,500/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (none in force (Korea-GCC FTA signed Dec 2023, not in force); WTO 0%)
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$850
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$140
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$25
Delivered	**$1,065**

United Arab Emirates

DISRUPTED

ADNOC Ruwais is INSIDE Hormuz. Strait of Hormuz effectively closed/restricted (28-29 Oct 2026: ~2-7% of normal traffic, mine strikes on tankers, Iran demands transit permits). Sulphur exits Gulf at ~55% of pre-war pace (Kpler, 26 Oct); Maersk suspended Gulf bookings; only ~2 containerships/week entering Gulf (Drewry wk 42). Majority of Gulf sulphur that does exit comes from Ruwais (Kpler). Containers possible via Khor Fakkan/Fujairah (outside strait) by truck; attacks reported near Sohar/Bukha 21 Oct.

Route: Truck Ruwais -> Khor Fakkan (east coast, outside Hormuz) -> container via Strait of Malacca -> Busan (truck+sea (containers), ~25 days)
Buy: $890/t FOB Ruwais bulk, ADNOC Oct 2026 OSP (contract; ME spot $740-790 FOB on 22 Oct). Small lots only via traders at a premium. · **Freight:** $2,500/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-UAE CEPA in force 1 May 2026 (HS 2503 coverage not confirmed; WTO 0% applies anyway))
Confidence: Medium

Purchase	$920
Origin fees + bagging	$16
Freight	$100
Insurance	$3
Korean duty	$0
Busan + delivery	$30
Finance + FX	$24
Delivered	**$1,094**

Azerbaijan

OPEN

No ban or sanctions found, but only minor refinery by-product sulphur; no 2026 export offers found. Not a practical source.

Route: Rail Baku -> Poti/Batumi (Georgia) -> sea via Suez/Red Sea -> Busan (rail+sea (containers), ~50 days)
Buy: n/a · **Freight:** $5,000/20ft · **Duty:** 2% (none; not WTO member -> 2% basic assumed)
Confidence: Low

No price available

Indonesia

OPEN

Not a realistic source: Indonesia is a major NET IMPORTER (1.85 Mt H1 2026 for nickel HPAL/acid; CFR Indonesia $850-860 on 22 Oct). Listed for completeness.

Route: Jakarta/Surabaya -> container to Busan (sea (containers), ~10 days)
Buy: n/a · **Freight:** $800/20ft · **Duty:** 0% (Korea-Indonesia CEPA, ASEAN-Korea, RCEP: 0%)
Confidence: Medium

No price available

05 · METHOD & SOURCES

How the numbers were built

• Lot sizes 100 t, 1,000 t; 20ft containers of 25 t bagged sulphur.

• Origin: export documents, certificate of origin and broker $1,500 per shipment; bagging $15/t.

• Insurance 0.3% of (FOB + freight) × 110%. Korean duty on CIF: 0% WTO rate for WTO members and FTA partners; 2% basic rate for non-WTO origins (UZ, TM, AZ, BY, IR, IQ).

• Korea: Busan THC/D-O + hazmat-licensed truck $750 per container; customs broker + chemical confirmation $350 per shipment. VAT 10% recoverable, so excluded from cost.

• Financing 8%/yr on landed cost over transit + 30 days payment terms; FX buffer 1%.

• Purchase prices and freight are October 2026 benchmarks and estimates, not supplier quotes. Bulk vessel shipments (3,000 t+) are roughly $70/t cheaper than containers.

• Hazardous-material rules: sulphur is a Class 2 flammable solid in Korea (designated quantity 100 kg); deliver from port straight to a licensed client site. K-REACH coverage needed at ≥ 1 t/yr.

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